

THE KHILADI: Method Behind the Hit Machine

Akshay Kumar was his usual unflappable self at the India Today conclave as he touched on everything from current affairs ("We stopped talking politics in the house almost five years ago") to six-packs ("People who get them do it through VFX or putting wrong things in the body"). Having acted in over 150 films over three decades, he reflected on a journey that has seen him negotiate ups and downs and even lateral contingency plans, like starting a cargo business in Canada.

"When I start making a film, I read it at least 100 times. That is why the flow of the film goes very fast, they can be finished in 50-55 days," he said. "That is why I can do four films in a year. I take Sundays off and a one-week vacation every three months."

Asked the secret of his energy, the actor credited his early-to-bed, early-to-rise routine and emphasis on fitness, nutrition and medical needs. He commented on the necessity for men above 50 to get a screening for prostate cancer annually as it affects one in three men. "I lost the most important person in my life, my father, at the age of 67 [to the disease]," he said. "You can save your life and the life of your family."

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- **Kumar reads a script many times before shooting begins, allowing tight, efficient scheduling and a yearly portfolio of up to four films**
- **He draws a lot from actor and martial artist Bruce Lee's philosophy to 'be like water': formless and adaptable**
- **Bollywood has historically neglected giving awards to comic actors because that genre of acting is unfairly seen as inferior to more 'serious' roles**

Kumar may have a National Award to his name for crime thriller *Rustom* (2016) and a reputation as India's nationalist hero due to films like *Airlift* (2016), *Gold* (2018) and *Kesari* (2019), but he identifies most with being "a commercial actor who is happy doing successful films". That explains his fondness for comedy franchises like *Housefull*. The idea of what clicks at the box-office, though, keeps changing and Kumar admitted that predicting what the audience wants is 'mission impossible'. "The film industry is like a circle. It keeps on changing every two, three years. Take *Dhurandhar*, an action film with bloodshed, people have lapped it up. Some time back, social films of mine like *Pad Man* and *Toilet: Ek Prem Katha* did really well. Now, the time for horror comedy films like *Stree* has come," he said.

Kumar also settled the controversy around his citizenship and fealty to India. Having spent time in Canada after a spate of flops, he received his citizenship documents in 2023 and voted for the first time in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. "There will be many good facets, but one problem will be highlighted and spun to get TRP," he said. "*Main Hindustani hoon aur hamesha rahoonga*." ■

Ask any big actor and they will tell you that comedy, making someone laugh, is the hardest. Unfortunately the genre has never gotten its due

I don't pick any roles or do work to build an image, nationalist or otherwise. I do it because the work is good and feels right to me

People spend Rs 350 per ticket at the cinema. I try to give them my best. I'll keep working in the industry till they shoot me down

I started my career with action, so consider myself a stuntman first. I set up an insurance plan for them because they often get hurt making us look good